For two years, A.A. Giri, the only teacher and principal of the Bapunagar Municipal Hindi Medium Middle School in the Rakhial area of Ahmedabad, had faced, and struggled against, an onerous task: teaching Algebra, Social Science, Biology, Chemistry and even Gujarati to 116 students of classes 9 and 10. After repeated requests, the school was allotted two visiting teaching assistants, appointed on contract by the state government. The three teachers are helping students prepare for the Gujarat Board Secondary School Certificate (SSC) examinations due to be held early next year. The visiting teachers are paid on per class taken basis, with a maximum of Rs 16,500 a month, substantially lower than the Rs 50,000-Rs 75,000 salary of a full-time senior teacher.

It's a plight 14 other institutions in the city are facing—forced to make do with woefully inadequate teaching staff. The situation is by no means restricted to the state capital, it is reflected all across Gujarat. Data presented in the state assembly in March 2023 shows 32,674 teaching posts lay vacant statewide as of December 2022. These vacancies comprise around 15 per cent of the total number of approved posts of teachers in government and government-aided schools. In all, 29,122 were for teachers and 3,522 for principals. Of these, 11,996 are unfilled in grant-in-aid/ government-aided schools, while 20,678 positions are yet to be filled in government-run schools. The situation in government and grant-in-aid primary schools is the direst—17,500 teaching posts are lying vacant in over 40,000 schools.

Gujarat has three kinds of schools—government schools (including those run by local bodies like municipalities), grant-in-aid schools and self-financed or private schools. Grant-in-aid schools are those operated by charitable organisations but fully funded by the government. These schools offer education free or at negligible cost. Teachers in these schools are appointed as full-time employees by the government through the Teacher Aptitude Test (TAT). Grant-in-aid schools assume importance in the rural and tribal areas of Gujarat, where private schools don't have a widespread presence. In all, there are 8.5 million primary school students, while 2.9 million students are enrolled in secondary and higher secondary grades across all three categories of schools in Gujarat. There are 12,764 secondary and higher secondary schools in Gujarat, of which 5,590 are grant-in-aid schools.

In recent years, school teachers in Gujarat have been demanding action on a host of issues. Around 75,000 teaching and non-teaching staff of 5,590 secondary and higher secondary grant-in-aid schools have been on strike for the past two months. Their two primary demands are the scrapping of a 14-year-old rule that linked government aid to grant schools with their performance in the SSC and Higher Secondary Certificate (HSC) board exams and the filling up of vacant teachers' positions.

The protesting association of grant-in-aid schools has pointed out that the result-linked grant policy was detrimental to students. Struggling schools in far-flung and backward areas, it argued, needed sustained help, not a punitive reduction in aid. The schools even threatened to shut down operations if the practice was not stopped. Finally, following five years of intensive protests, the government withdrew the performance-linked grants system in the last week of August. "Hundreds of schools have shut down in the last decade—140 in 2022 itself, due to this draconian policy, which was finally withdrawn last month," says Dhiren Vyas, former member of the Gujarat Secondary and Higher Secondary Education Board (GSHSEB). However, officials say that result-linked grants were meant to improve the quality of teaching by doing away inefficiency.

However, the greater battle—that of filling the widespread vacancies with full-time teachers—remains to be won. Missing teachers in classrooms, the protesters claim, is rotting Gujarat's education system at its core.

32,674
No. of posts of teachers and principals lying vacant in Gujarat's government and government-aided schools

17,500
No. of primary teachers' posts yet to be filled up

5,612
No. of government schools either shut down or merged in the past three years due to lack of students

Source: Gujarat government